



How healthy is an air fryer?

What you should know before buying one

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I recently bought an air fryer because I wanted crispy food without the health-related guilt that usually comes with deep-fried snacks. As someone who hates standing in the kitchen waiting for food to cook, it also sounded like a simple enough solution. I can put the food in the basket, add little or no oil depending on what I'm making, set the temperature and let it cook.

Using less oil obviously sounds healthier on paper, but an air fryer isn't a magic box that turns everything you put inside healthy, food or no. And that got me thinking... What actually changes when you cook the same food in an air

fryer instead of deep frying it traditionally in a whole lot of oil? And how much difference does using less oil really make? I decided to dig into it, and here's what I found. Of course, this article isn't health advice of any sort, and you should read and explore more clinical data before taking the plunge.

What actually happens inside an air fryer?

Despite the name, an air fryer doesn't really fry food. It uses a heating element and a fan to circulate hot air around the food. The basket has holes that let the air move around the food, helping the surface brown and crisp. In that sense,

an air fryer is closer to a small convection oven than a deep fryer.

The airflow is also why you can't just fill the basket to the top and expect the same result. I have noticed this with potato wedges and fries. When there is some space between them, they brown much better. Pack the basket too tightly and some pieces stay softer than others.

The real health advantage is the oil

Deep frying means the food is surrounded by hot oil while it cooks. With an air fryer, many foods need only a small amount of oil, while some don't require any additional oil at all. According to a 2024 Cleveland Clinic report, air frying can reduce calories from added fat compared with deep frying because considerably less oil is being used and consumed.

I notice this most when I'm making something like potato wedges. I can lightly coat them with oil, put them in the basket and leave them to cook on their own. With deep frying, I'd need a whole pan of oil for the same job, and then I'd also have to figure out what to do with the leftover oil afterwards.

There is a catch, though. The air fryer isn't removing the fat that's already in the food. Frozen fries, nuggets and packaged snacks can contain plenty of oil and fat before they even go into the basket. The difference is mainly in how much additional oil you will require during cooking.

The basket coating is worth checking too

There is another part of an air fryer that doesn't get much attention: the surface your food is actually sitting on. Many air fryers use non-stick coatings, with PTFE being one common option. Other models use ceramic coatings or stainless-steel cooking surfaces. Philips, for example, says most of its air-fryer pans, baskets and meshes use a PTFE coating, while some meshes in